CONCERT ▸

Making Music in Nature's Lap

Padma Vibhushan and Grammy-winning sarod exponent **Ustad Amjad Ali Khan** talks about the *Ragas by the River* festival where he is performing

Q. What is *Ragas by the River* all about?

Ragas by the River is a special musical gathering set in the tranquil surroundings of Jim Corbett National Park. The idea behind the festival is to celebrate Indian classical music in harmony with nature. Corbett, with its pristine forests, flowing river and peaceful atmosphere, creates a magical environment where music feels deeply connected to the natural world. Holding the festival annually is our way of bringing together music lovers, artists and nature enthusiasts to celebrate both cultural heritage and environmental awareness. It reminds us that art and nature are deeply intertwined, and that both deserve our respect and protection.

Q. What will you be performing at the festival?

I will be presenting a selection of traditional ragas that celebrate the beauty of the evening and night, along with compositions from the rich repertoire of the Senia Bangash tradition. My sons will also join me, and together we hope to create a musical journey that reflects both devotion to tradition and the joy of shared creativity. What makes it all the more special is that I will also be joined on stage by my grandsons, Abeer and Zohaan, who are wildlife enthusiasts, and have appeared in the track 'Kabini' in Amaan and Ayaan's album, *Celebrating Our Tigers*.

Q. Recently, you won your first Grammy Award in the Best Audio Book, Narration, and Storytelling Recording category, along with your sons. How does it feel?

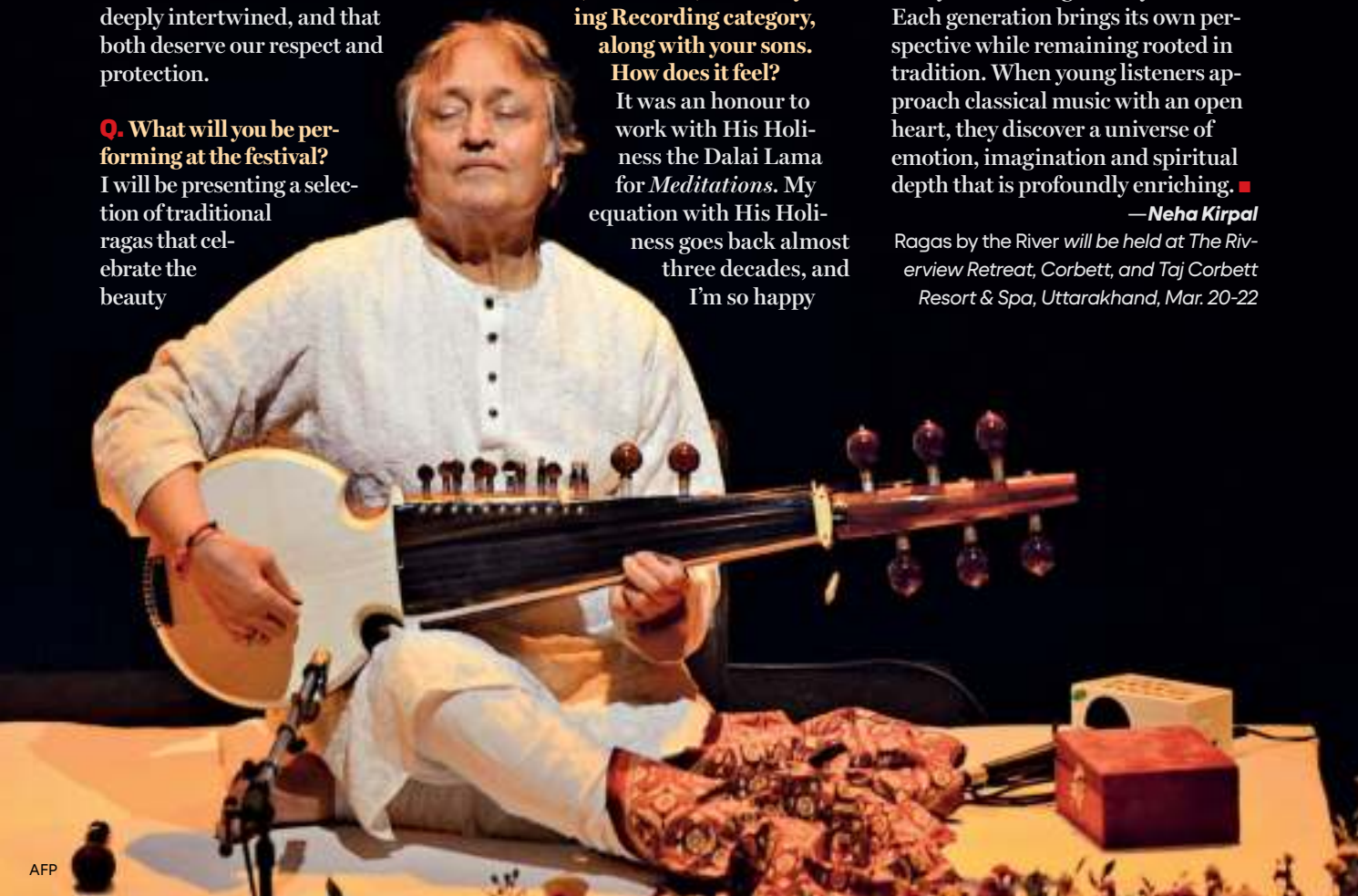
It was an honour to work with His Holiness the Dalai Lama for *Meditations*. My equation with His Holiness goes back almost three decades, and I'm so happy and thrilled that this win happened in his 90th birth year. Music has always been a sacred journey in our family, passed down through generations with love and dedication. To share this recognition with my sons made the moment even more meaningful.

Q. What is the relevance of classical music for today's generation?

In today's fast-paced world, young people are constantly searching for meaning, balance and inner peace. Classical music offers exactly that—it is a pathway to introspection, discipline and creativity. Music has always evolved organically with time. Each generation brings its own perspective while remaining rooted in tradition. When young listeners approach classical music with an open heart, they discover a universe of emotion, imagination and spiritual depth that is profoundly enriching. ■

—Neha Kirpal

Ragas by the River *will be held at The Riverview Retreat, Corbett, and Taj Corbett Resort & Spa, Uttarakhand, Mar. 20-22*



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